FREE CARDS

Shaving and Hygiene Steps

Task-analysis step cards for showering, deodorant, brushing teeth and shaving, plus a weekly routine chart.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic young people, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE
Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA

Easy read

I wash my body and my teeth. I use deodorant. Shaving is my choice. I follow the steps.

How to use this resource

- Teach one routine at a time. Practise the steps with your young person over several weeks.
- Cut out the cards. Put them in order on the bathroom wall, laminated, or on a ring.
- Fade support slowly. Start by doing it with them, then beside them, then watching, then checking.
- Use the weekly chart to tick off each step. Ticks are for pride and routine, not for checking up.
- Try the sensory tips. Many young people find water, smells or razors hard. Changing the tool often solves it.

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Version 1.0 · shaving-and-hygiene-steps

Showering

1



Get ready

Get a clean towel and clean clothes. Put them where I can reach them.

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2



Undress

Take off my clothes. Put them in the wash basket.

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3



Turn on water

Turn on the water. Test it with my hand. Make it warm, not hot.

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4



Get wet

Step in. Wet my hair and body.

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5



Wash

Use shampoo for hair. Use soap or body wash for body. Wash under arms, between legs, bottom and feet.

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6



Rinse

Rinse all the soap and shampoo off. Turn off the water.

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7



Dry

Dry my body with a towel. Dry between my toes and under my arms.

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8



Dress

Put on clean underwear and clothes.

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9



Tidy up

Hang the towel. Put dirty clothes in the wash basket.

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Using deodorant

1



Start clean

Deodorant works best on clean, dry skin. Use it after a shower.

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2



Get deodorant

Choose roll-on, stick or spray. Remove the lid.

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3



Lift an arm

Lift one arm. Keep the arm up.

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4



Apply

Swipe two or three times under the arm. For spray, press for 2 seconds from 15 cm away.

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5



Other arm

Do the same under the other arm.

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6



Wait

Wait a minute, then get dressed. Put the lid back on.

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Brushing teeth

1



Get ready

Get my toothbrush and a pea-sized amount of fluoride toothpaste.

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2



Wet brush

Wet the brush a little.

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3



Brush for 2 minutes

Brush the front, back and top of every tooth. Use a timer or song.

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4



Brush my tongue

Gently brush my tongue.

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5



Spit and rinse

Spit out the toothpaste. Do not rinse with lots of water. Rinse the brush.

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6



Twice a day

Morning and night. See the dentist once a year.

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Shaving my face (electric razor)

Shaving is a **choice**. Some people shave, some do not. An **electric razor** is recommended for learners. It is safer than a blade, quieter than many people expect, and has no cream or water mess. Wet shaving with a blade can cause cuts and needs more practice.

1



Check

Check the razor is clean and charged. A trusted adult helps the first times.

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2



Dry face

Wash and dry my face. Electric razors work on dry skin.

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3



Stretch skin

Hold the skin flat with my free hand.

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4



Move slowly

Move the razor in small gentle circles or lines. Do not press hard.

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5



Check

Look in the mirror. Feel with my hand. Go over missed spots.

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6



Clean up

Brush hair out of the razor. Put it away. Moisturise if my skin feels dry.

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Shaving legs and underarms: my choice

Hair on legs and under arms is normal. Some people remove it, some do not. It is **your** choice. Nobody has to do it. Do not do it because of pressure from others. If you choose to remove hair, an electric razor or trimmer is gentle. Ask a trusted adult to show you.

1



Choose

Do I want to? It is okay to say yes or no.

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2



Get ready

Use a clean razor. Sit in a safe place, like the bath edge or a chair.

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3



Shave gently

Move in the direction of hair growth. Go slowly. Do not press hard.

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4



Rinse and dry

Rinse off hair. Pat dry. Use a gentle moisturiser if needed.

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5



If I get a cut

Press a clean tissue on it. Tell an adult. Put on a plaster.

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6



Clean up

Rinse the razor. Put it away. Never share razors.

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My weekly routine chart

Tick each box when you do it. Decide with your adult which steps go on your chart.

My routine

Step	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Brush teeth (morning)							
Brush teeth (night)							
Shower or wash							
Use deodorant							
Put on clean underwear and socks							
Shave (if I choose to)							
Wash hair (twice a week)							

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Sensory tips

- **Water:** If the shower is too loud or too strong, try a softer head, a bath, or a wash at the sink. A timer or music can help.
- **Smell:** Choose unscented products if smells bother you. Try small amounts first.
- **Touch:** Soft towels and soft, tagless clothes help. Pat dry rather than rub.
- **Sound:** Electric razors buzz. Try ear defenders, or one that is quieter.
- **Toothpaste:** If mint is too strong, try a mild or flavourless fluoride toothpaste. Ask the dentist.
- **Routine:** Do it in the same order at the same time every day. A visual schedule reduces stress.

Notes for adults

- Break each routine into steps and teach one step at a time (task analysis). Praise effort, not perfection.
- Do not shame about body smell or hair. Say 'Your body is growing. Here is how we look after it.'
- Offer choices. 'Shower now or in 10 minutes?' 'Roll-on or stick?' Choice supports independence.
- Hair removal is a choice, especially for girls and women. Do not pressure. Do not assume.
- Teach razor safety: never share a razor, keep razors out of reach of younger children, and replace blades or heads regularly.
- Some young people will need long-term support with personal care. Build their independence at their own pace and protect their privacy and dignity.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 2 **Making Healthy Choices** and Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality**: personal care, hygiene and body changes.
- Senior Cycle SPHE (new specification, 2024) and LCA Social Education: independent living and personal care skills.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: teach daily living skills in small steps with visual supports.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Your GP or public health nurse

For questions about puberty, periods, body changes or health checks.

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Text About It

Free text support any time: text HELLO to 50808.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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